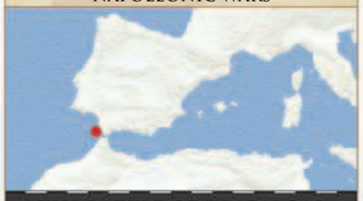
NAPOLEONIC WARS



THE BATTLE OF TRAFALGAR

Date	October 21, 1805
Location	Off Cape Trafalgar, southern Spain
Result	British victory

COMBATANTS

BRITAIN	FRANCE AND SPAIN

COMMANDERS

Horatio Nelson	Pierre-Charles Villeneuve Federico Gravina

FORCES

Ships: 27 ships of the line	**Ships:** 33 ships of the line

LOSSES

Men: 449 killed, 1,246 wounded **Ships:** none	**Men:** 4,500 killed, 2,400 wounded, c.7,000 taken prisoner **Ships:** 1 sunk, 17 captured

THE BATTLE OF TRAFALGAR

In summer 1805 Emperor Napoleon was encamped with his Grande Armée at Boulogne, ready to invade Britain. He required the French navy and its Spanish allies to guarantee the non-intervention of the Royal Navy for sufficient days to get his army across the Channel. The French Mediterranean squadron under Vice Admiral Pierre-Charles Villeneuve succeeded in joining up with the Spanish under Admiral Federico Gravina, but failed to help France's Atlantic squadron escape the British blockade at Brest. Pessimistic about his chances of victory against the Royal Navy, Villeneuve took refuge with the Spanish at Cadiz. Napoleon abandoned his invasion plan. Furious with Villeneuve, he ordered another admiral take over his command.

Through September the British assembled a fleet off Cadiz. Admiral Nelson arrived to take command of this blockade force on September 29. His frigates kept watch on the Spanish port while his ships of the line waited beyond sight of shore. Despite having an inferior force by any count of ships, guns, or men, Nelson planned a battle of annihilation. He intended to attack in two columns, cutting the French-Spanish line so the center and rear squadrons were isolated from the van. His captains would then use their initiative to win a "pell-mell" battle.

> "I WAS AWAKENED BY THE CHEERS OF THE CREW AND THEIR RUSHING TO GET A GLIMPSE OF THE HOSTILE FLEET."
>
> **BRITISH OFFICER,** DESCRIBING THE JOY OF ARRIVING AT TRAFALGAR

Meanwhile, Villeneuve decided to sail before his replacement arrived, hoping to redeem his honour. On October 19, with much delay and confusion, the 33 French and Spanish ships of the line began to leave Cadiz. The following day, they headed for Gibraltar with Nelson's ships in pursuit. After some confused maneuvering, daybreak on October 21 found the two fleets near Cape Trafalgar. At around 7:30 a.m. Villeneuve ordered his fleet to wear together and turn back for Cadiz. He did not in fact

